

Word Choice Matters, Choose with Care¹⁻³

Language that centers of who the patient is			
Guiding Principle	Rationale	Non-Person-centered example	Person-centered example
Person-first language	People are more than their conditions. Avoid using adjectives as nouns. Terms should acknowledge a patient's humanity first. Note that certain communities prefer identify-first language (i.e., Autism, Deaf communities). When in doubt ask the person's preference.	<i>Patient is a diabetic</i> <i>Patient is a sickler; bipolar</i> <i>The patient is a vasculopath</i> <i>The 52-year-old person with deafness presenting with pneumonia</i>	<i>Patient with diabetes</i> <i>Patient with sickle cell disease; with bipolar disorder; has peripheral vascular disease</i> <i>The 52-year-old deaf patient presenting with pneumonia.</i>
Choose non-pejorative terms	Loaded terms propagate negative attitudes and influence care. Criminal-legal terms and combat language should generally be avoided.	<i>The drug screen is dirty</i> <i>Drug-seeking, substance abuse, addict</i> <i>IV Drug User</i> <i>Relapse</i> <i>Risky sexual behavior</i> <i>Committed suicide</i> <i>Homeless person</i> <i>Obese</i> <i>Ex-Convict</i> <i>Illegal immigrant</i> <i>Cancer victim; cancer battle</i>	<i>The drug screen is positive</i> <i>Person with substance use disorder, opioid use disorder</i> <i>Person who injects drugs</i> <i>Recurrence of drug use</i> <i>Condomless sex</i> <i>Died by suicide</i> <i>Patient experiencing homelessness</i> <i>Person with obesity; The patient's BMI is</i> <i>Person with a history of incarceration</i> <i>People with undocumented status</i> <i>Person living with cancer</i>
Use caution when leading with race, ethnicity, language, socioeconomic status and other social identifiers	Leading with identifiers in the one-liner propagates bias and reifies biologic race. Be intentional and specific when using social identifiers. Beware of assumptions—self report of identifiers is best.	<i>65-year-old African American male presents with abdominal pain.</i> <i>32-year-old Hispanic woman presents with fever.</i> <i>87-year-old Bengali speaking man presents with leg swelling.</i> <i>23-year-old unemployed woman presents with cough.</i>	<i>65-year-old presents with abdominal pain.</i> <i>32-year-old woman presents with fever.</i> <i>87-year-old Bengali man presents with leg swelling.</i> <i>23-year-old woman presents with cough.</i>
Choose inclusive language	Utilize the person's correct pronouns. When in doubt, use neutral pronouns. Transgender is an adjective, not a noun. Regarding disability, acknowledge circumstances but avoid disempowering narratives.	<i>Documentation includes assigned at birth pronoun.</i> <i>Disabled person; Developmentally disabled</i> <i>Wheelchair-Bound</i> <i>Bed-bound</i>	<i>When relevant to care, note assigned sex at birth; gender identity; refers to a trans woman as she</i> <i>Person with a disability; Person with a developmental disability</i> <i>Uses a wheelchair</i> <i>Unable to leave their bed</i>

Language that centers on patients' actions and decisions around their health			
Guiding Principle	Rationale	Non-Person-centered example	Person-centered example
Use language that does not attribute responsibility to patients for their conditions	When possible, identify systems or provider-level barriers that can be mitigated. Poor verb choice compromises the credibility of the patient's narrative and implies the narrator is unreliable. Language should not ascribe blame or judgment.	<i>Underserved people/communities/the underserved</i> <i>The patient failed outpatient treatment</i> <i>He is refusing oxygen therapy</i> <i>She is refusing to be admitted</i> <i>Poorly controlled hypertension.</i> <i>Frequent flier</i> <i>The patient claims she is taking her insulin</i>	<i>People who are underserved by mental health resources</i> <i>The antibiotics did not work for this infection</i> <i>He is not tolerating oxygen therapy because</i> <i>She is declining admission because</i> <i>The patient's blood pressure control is impacted by barriers in accessing care like transportation</i> <i>The patient has been to the ED multiple time for this condition due to X</i> <i>The patient reports adherence to her insulin regimen</i>
Conveys trust in the patient Use non-judgmental language	The history of present illness is a subjective experience. The patient's story should not include the use interrogation terms.	<i>Claims, alleges, denies, insists, endorses; difficult patient, frequent flier</i> <i>He denies shortness of breath</i> <i>He endorses chest pain</i> <i>The patient's chief complaint is</i> <i>The pleasant patient</i> <i>The patient failed to follow his diet order</i> <i>The patient insists she has back pain</i>	<i>Describes; is experiencing, has</i> <i>He is not short of breath</i> <i>He is having chest pain</i> <i>The patient's chief concern is</i> <i>The patient is in no acute distress</i> <i>The patient had some solid food while on a NPO diet</i> <i>The patient has back pain</i>
Choose language that does not weaponize quotations	Recognize times when quotations can be useful such as when describing the quality of a symptoms.	<i>He insists he has a "seizure disorder"</i> <i>She claims the pain is "horrible"</i>	<i>He reports episodes of seizure like activity</i> <i>She reports that her pain is a 10/10</i>
Demonstrates shared decision making	Emphasizing physician authority or expressing disapproval of patient reasoning impacts the patient-physician relationship	<i>He was told to</i> <i>I informed her</i> <i>Left AMA</i>	<i>We discussed x and agreed to</i> <i>I shared with her</i> <i>The patient chose to leave prior to conclusion of treatment due to X; The patient left before medically advised after a risk/benefit discussion</i>

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2. Park J, Saha S, Chee B, Taylor J, Beach MC. Physician Use of Stigmatizing Language in Patient Medical Records. *JAMA Netw Open*. 2021;4(7):e2117052. doi:10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2021.17052
3. Kleinman RA, Brothers TD, Morris NP. Retiring the "Against Medical Advice" Discharge. *Ann Intern Med*. 2022;175(12):1761-1762. doi:10.7326/M22-2964